

Mengkai Wang

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EDUCATION

DEGREE PROGRAMS

Beijing Foreign Studies University

Beijing, China

Bachelor of Arts in English (Linguistics)

2022 - 2026

GPA: 3.80/4

NON-DEGREE PROGRAMS

Linguistics Institute of China

Beijing Institute of Technology

2025

North American Summer School in Logic, Language, and Information (NASSLLI)

University of Washington

2025

RESEARCH INTERESTS

BROAD

Cognitive Science; Neurolinguistics; Syntactic Theory; (Formal and Experimental) Syntax

NARROW

Island Effects in Syntax; Language/Sentence Processing; Syntactic Processing; Psycholinguistics (Syntactic Perspective); Interfaces between Syntax and Semantics/Pragmatics

PUBLICATIONS

JOURNALS

- [1] **Wang, M.** (under review). An Experimental Investigation of Acceptability Variations of *Wh*-Island Effects in Chinese. *Folia Linguistica*.
- [2] **Wang, M.** (under review). Frequency Effects and Acceptability Judgments: Revisiting the Coordinate Structure Constraint. *Empirical Issues in Syntax and Semantics*.
- [3] **Wang, M.** (under review). A Meta-analysis of Cross-linguistic Syntactic Island Effects. *Language, Cognition, and Neuroscience*.
- [4] **Wang, M.** (under review). Constructing Evidentiality: A Baseline/Elaboration Approach to the Grounding Process in Chinese. *Cognitive Semantics*.
- [5] **Wang, M.** (under review). Constraint Silencing and Satiation Generalization: Evidence for Shared Cognitive Loci. *Linguistics Vanguard*.

CONFERENCE PROCEEDINGS

- [6] **Wang, M.** (2025). Evaluating the Linguistic Competence of Large Language Models: Experimental Evidence from Center-embedding Structures. *Proceedings of The 47th Annual Conference of Cognitive Science Society*.
- [7] **Wang, M.** (2025). Experimental Evidence on Requests in English Varieties from the Perspective of Local Grammars. *Proceedings of The 16th International Conference on Linguistic Research and Applications*.
- [8] **Wang, M.** (2025). Island Effects and Amelioration by Resumption in Hong Kong English: An Auditory Acceptability-judgement Study. *Proceedings of The 16th International Conference on Linguistic Research and Applications*.
- [9] **Wang, M.** (2025). Evaluating Advanced EFL Learners' Writing Performance Assisted by Large Language Models. *Proceedings of The*

- [10] **Wang, M.** & Gao, Y. (2025). AI-Driven Personalized Language Learning: Customizing Content and Feedback to Learners' Needs and Proficiency Levels. *Proceedings of The 23rd International CALL Research Conference*.
- [11] **Wang, M.** (2025). Does Nominalization Exist in Mandarin Chinese: *de* as the Morphological Marker. *Proceedings of The 7th International Conference on Linguistics and Language Studies*.

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREPARATION

- [12] **Wang, M.**, Chang, J., & Liu, J. Embodied Navigation Intelligence of LLMs.
- [13] **Wang, M.**, He, J., & Liu, J. What is AI Literacy? A Scale from the General.
- [14] **Wang, M.** On the Differences of the Pre-/Post-posing Complements of NPs between Chinese and English.
- [15] **Wang, M.** On the Classifications of *de* in Chinese NPs.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

ORAL PRESENTATIONS

- [1] **Wang, M.** (2026). The Cost of Silence: Processing Constraints on Elliptical Strategies. *The 101st Annual Meeting of Linguistic Society of America (LSA-101)*, New Orleans, America.
- [2] **Wang, M.** (2026). Deconstructing L2 exposure: How input dimensions shape child CAF development. *The 50th Annual Meeting of American Association for Applied Linguistics (AAAL-50)*, Chicago, America.
- [3] **Wang, M.** & Yue, C. (2026). The role of syntactic priming in child second language development: An experimental study. *The 50th Annual Meeting of American Association for Applied Linguistics (AAAL-50)*, Chicago, America.
- [4] **Wang, M.** (2025). Man vs. Machine: A Comparative Eye-Tracking Study on the Processing of Human- and AI-Generated Corrective Feedback in SCMC. *The 59th Annual Meeting of Australian Linguistic Society (ALS-59)*, Queensland, Australia.
- [5] **Wang, M.** & Yue, C. (2025). Making the Implicit Salient: The Effect of Input Enhancement on the Processing and Acquisition of Morpho-Syntactic Feedback in SCMC. *The 59th Annual Meeting of Australian Linguistic Society (ALS-59)*, Queensland, Australia.
- [6] **Wang, M.** (2025). An Experimental Investigation of Soft and Hard Presupposition Triggers in English. *The 19th International Pragmatics Conference (IPrA-19)*, Brisbane, Australia.
- [7] **Wang, M.** & Liang, S. (2025). Exploring the Impact of AI Literacy and Contextual Factors on Students' Utilization of AI-Generated Feedback in Writing Revisions. *The 58th British Association for Applied Linguistics Conference (BAAL-58)*, Glasgow, Britain.
- [8] **Wang, M.** (2025). Experimental Evidence on Requests in English Varieties from the Perspective of Local Grammars. *The 16th International Conference on Linguistic Research and Applications (ICLRA-16)*, Paris, France.
- [9] **Wang, M.** (2025). Island Effects and Amelioration by Resumption in Hong Kong English: An Auditory Acceptability-judgement Study. *The 16th International Conference on Linguistic Research and Applications (ICLRA-16)*, Paris, France.
- [10] **Wang, M.** (2025). Experimental Evidence on Sluicing and Adjunct Islands. *The 11th International Conference on Formal Linguistics (ICFL-11)*, Guangzhou, China.
- [11] **Wang, M.** (2025). GenAI as a writing assistant? A corpus-based study on lexical and syntactic complexity of GPT-post-edited learner academic writing. *The 9th Hong Kong Association for Applied Linguistics Conference (HAAL-9)*, Hong Kong, China.
- [12] **Wang, M.** (2025). Does Nominalization Exist in Mandarin Chinese: *de* as the Morphological Marker. *The 7th International Conference on Linguistics and Language Studies (ICLLS-7)*, Ningbo, China.
- [13] **Wang, M.** (2025). Evaluating Advanced EFL Learners' Writing Abilities Assisted by LLMs. *The 11th International Hybrid Conference on Second Language Studies (ICSLS-11)*, Istanbul, Turkey. (Accepted but not presented)
- [14] **Wang, M.** (2024). A Corpus-based Cognitive Comparative Study of Concession Compound Sentences in Chinese and English. *The 6th International Cognitive Semantics Conference (ICSC-6)*, Tianjin, China.

POSTER SESSIONS

- [15] **Wang, M.** (2025). Evaluating the Linguistic Competence of Large Language Models: Experimental Evidence from Center-embedding Structures. *The 47th Annual Conference of Cognitive Science Society*, San Francisco, America.
- [16] **Wang, M.** (2025). A Study on Evidentiality System in Chinese from the Perspective of Baseline/Elaboration. *The 17th International*

- [17] **Wang, M.**, & Yue, C. (2025). On the Classifications of Chinese Relative Complex Sentences from the Perspective of Baseline/Elaboration. *The 17th International Cognitive Linguistics Conference (ICLC-17), Buenos Aires, Argentina.*
- [18] Wang, Y., & **Wang, M.** (2025). Does Code-switching represent Language Deficit: Evidence from Mandarin-English Dual-Language-Learning Children in the U.S. *The 15th International Symposium on Bilingualism (IBS-15), Donostia-san Sebastián, Spain.*
- [19] **Wang, M.** (2025). A Corpus-based Study on Syntactic Fossilization of *Wh*-Islands. *The 13th International Corpus Linguistics Conference (CL-13), Birmingham, Britain.*
- [20] **Wang, M.**, & Lin, Y. (2025). A Corpus-based Study of *China Men* on the Deformation of Chinese Narrative in Back Translation. *The 13th International Corpus Linguistics Conference (CL-13), Birmingham, Britain.*
- [21] **Wang, M.** (2025). Evaluating Advanced EFL Learners' Writing Performance Assisted by Large Language Models. *The 23rd International CALL Research Conference (CALL-23), Brisbane, Australia.*
- [22] **Wang, M.** & Gao, Y. (2025). AI-Driven Personalized Language Learning: Customizing Content and Feedback to Learners' Needs and Proficiency Levels. *The 23rd International CALL Research Conference (CALL-23), Brisbane, Australia.*
- [23] **Wang, M.** (2025). A Test of the Relation between *Wh*-Acceptability and Syntactic *Surprisals* in Recurrent Neural Networks. *The 64th Annual Meeting of the Linguistics Association of Great Britain and Northern Ireland (LAGB-64), Ipswich, Britain.*
- [24] **Wang, M.** & Yue, C. (2025). The Impact of Pre-Reading Morphological Instruction on the Acquisition of Syntactically Complex Words. *The 64th Annual Meeting of the Linguistics Association of Great Britain and Northern Ireland (LAGB-64), Ipswich, Britain.*
- [25] **Wang, M.** (under review). Experimental Evidence: Exploring the Puzzle of Children Processing in Identifying *Wh*-movements. *The 50th Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD-50), Boston, America.*

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

SELF-SUPERVISED RESEARCH

Research on Experimental-syntactic Investigations on *Wh*-Island Effects

Principal Investigator

May. 2024 - Present

Supported by *the Fundamental Research Funds for Central Universities (No. 2024JX078)*

- Designed and pre-tested stimuli, and recruited 50 native speakers and conducted acceptability-judgment experiments via Ibox Farm.
- Analyzed data in R using mixed-effects models; interpreted interaction effects between *wh*-elements and acceptability ratings.
- Prepared manuscript uploaded to LingBuzz, and targeting submission to a leading psycholinguistics journal.

Research on Concession Compound Sentences in Chinese and English from a Cognitive Perspective

Principal Investigator

Sep. 2023 - Jan. 2024

- Developed a bilingual corpus of 1,200 complex concession sentences in English and Mandarin Chinese.
- Processed data in Python and R; performed quantitative analyses to identify semantic and processing differences.
- Coordinated a writing team and presented findings at the 6th International Cognitive Semantics Conference.

RESEARCH ASSISTANTSHIPS

Research on the Behavioral Experiments of Vowel Formant Calculations in Modern Phonetics

Research Assistant | Supervisor: Assoc. Prof. Ting Zou, Beijing Foreign Studies University

Dec. 2024 - Present

- Programmed eye-tracking experiments using Eyelink 1000 to capture real-time vowel perception in 50 participants.
- Processed and analyzed acoustic data using Praat, and collaborated on experimental design to investigate regional vowel formant shifts in north-regional dialects.
- Summarized results in monthly lab reports.

Research on the Minimalist Program in Generative Syntactic Studies

Research Assistant | Supervisor: Assoc. Prof. Xiaoshi Hu, Tsinghua University

Sep. 2024 - Jan. 2025

- This project focuses on how the Minimalist Program is applied and functions in languages from a micro syntactic perspective. It is predicted to generate several high-quality theoretical papers.

- Sorted and discussed literature for paper writing.

Research on Artificial Intelligence and Large Language Models

Research Assistant | Supervisor: Prof. Fuzhen Si, Beijing Language and Culture University

Sep. 2024 - Jan. 2025

- This project explores the practicality and development of artificial intelligence and large language models under linguistic backgrounds to probe into the possibility of the interaction between AI and human language acquisition.
- Collected human participants' data and participated in paper writing.

Research on Cartographic Theory in Generative Syntactic Tree Diagrams

Research Assistant | Supervisor: Prof. Fuzhen Si, Beijing Language and Culture University

Sep. 2024 - Dec. 2024

- This project researches how tree diagrams develop and can be further in terms of cartographic theories in generative syntax to simplify syntax in language, thus helping humans behave better in syntax.
- Participated in literature discussion, and completed literature searching, data analyzing, and part of paper writing.

Research on Interpretation and Application of Autonomous Knowledge Production

Research Assistant | Supervisor: Prof. Lian Zhang, Beijing Foreign Studies University

Sep. 2024 - Dec. 2024

Supported by *Philosophy and Social Science Foundation of China*

- This project explores how national standards for teaching in foreign languages and literatures in universities can be interpreted and applied based on various applied linguistic theories and methods.
- Collected and processed data, and finished selecting the literature.

Research on Code-switching in Mandarin-English Dual-Language-Learning Preschoolers in the United States

Research Assistant | Supervisor: Ph.D. student Yifei Wang, University of California, Los Angeles

Jul. 2024 - Dec. 2024

- This project is conducted to challenge the traditional single-language-system theory by analyzing the collected language data from American Chinese-English bilingual children.
- Transcribed and analyzed recorded data into texts, and used CLAN to calculate MLU, which is the core statistics accounting for code-switching in Mandarin-English Dual-Language-Learning Preschoolers.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

TEACHING ASSISTANTSHIPS

Introduction to Syntax

Instructor: Prof. Fuzhen Si (Dept. of Linguistics, Beijing Language and Culture University)

Fall 2024

Theory of Syntactic Cartography

Instructor: Prof. Fuzhen Si (Dept. of Linguistics, Beijing Language and Culture University)

Fall 2024

GUEST LECTURES

Methods in Academic Paper Writing, given at *Beijing Foreign Studies University*

Nov. 2024

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

AI of Brain & Cognition Center at Tsinghua Laboratory of Brain and Intelligence

Research Intern

May 2025 - Present

Program 1

- Discussed literature on AI-agent connectedness for artificial navigation in embodied environments, and participated in regular in-person meetings, and analyzed and corrected 10,000+ Python codes and data.
- Organized and completed literature review and selection for features influencing navigation, and delivered highly controllable and diverse 3D environment stimuli for cognitive experiments.
- Established a parameter and rule-based environmental complexity control system supporting automatic generation of different difficulty experimental conditions, and developed data storage and analysis tool-chains providing a solid foundation for subsequent experimental result analysis.

Program 2

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- Co-developed the Adult AI Literacy Scale; conducted rigorous reliability/validity tests and multiple regression analysis using [SPSS/R/Python].
- Authored the first draft of a research manuscript based on quantitative findings, summarizing key predictors of AI literacy.
- Adapted and developed a tailored AI Literacy Scale for adolescents to assess youth understanding of artificial intelligence.
- Built a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) system and engineered web crawlers to automate data acquisition and enhance research workflows.

Research Center for Digital Humanities at Peking University

<i>Research Intern</i>	Nov. 2024 - May 2025
● Participated in the development and maintenance of digital humanities infrastructure, and assisted in demand analysis, system design, coding implementation, test optimization. ● Assisted in web development in humanities and social sciences to further protect ancient books, and participated in designing the website “Wu & Dian”. ● Cooperated in the writing of technical documents and academic papers.	

The Sixth Forum on China-Africa Media Cooperation & China-Africa Think Tank High-Level Dialogue

<i>Interpreter Intern</i>	Jul. 2024 - Aug. 2024
● Conducted forum sign-ins for ministers from various African countries. ● Interpreted the meetings at this dialogue for 4 foreign guests (including a minister) from Zimbabwe, and interpreted BIRTV Chinese explaining for all African guests.	

EXTRACURRICULAR EXPERIENCE

Reading Group of Frontier Syntactic Work at Tsinghua University	
<i>Core Member</i>	Sep. 2024 - Dec. 2024
Beijing Foreign Language Institution Alliance	
<i>President</i>	Sep. 2023 - Present
2024 CIEE UNHCR Student Challenge	
<i>Team Leader</i>	Feb. 2024 - Apr. 2024
Summer Student Practice of BFSU	
<i>Team Leader</i>	Jul. 2023

HONORS & AWARDS

FUNDS	
The Fundamental Research Funds for Central Universities (\$700)	2024

AWARDS	
Student Award of Merit, Beijing Foreign Studies University	2023, 2025
Outstanding Student Leaders, Beijing Foreign Studies University	2024
First-Class Prize of the 14 th Business Plan Challenge Cup	2024
First-Place in Beijing Foreign Studies University Sports Meeting Cheerleading Competition	2024
Merit in University-level Undergraduate Innovation and Entrepreneurship Training Program	2024
First-Class Prize of the 18 th Academic Project Challenge Cup	2023

SCHOLARSHIPS	
First-Class Scholarship, Beijing Foreign Studies University (\$410)	2023, 2025
Shi Sheng Qing Scholarship, Beijing Foreign Studies University (\$410)	2024

MEMBERSHIP

The International Linguistic Society (ILS)	2025 - Present
Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL)	2025 - Present
International Society of Experimental Linguistics (ExLing)	2025 - Present
Society for Human Sentence Processing (SHSP)	2025 - Present
Cognitive Science Society (CSS)	2025 - Present
Linguistic Society of America (LSA)	2024 - Present
Generative Linguistics in the Old World (GLOW)	2024 - Present
International Association of Chinese Linguistics (IACL)	2024 - Present
International Pragmatics Association (IPrA)	2024 - Present
International Cognitive Linguistics Association (ICLA)	2024 - Present

ACADEMIC SERVICE

JOURNAL REVIEWER

Natural Language & Linguistic Theory (SSCI, IF: 3.6); Frontiers in Psychology (SSCI, IF: 2.6); Humanities & Social Sciences Communications (SSCI, IF: 3.7)

CONFERENCE REVIEWER

Cognitive Science Society (CSS); Society for Computation in Linguistics (SCiL); International Pragmatics Conference (IPrC); Generative Linguistics in the Old World Conference (GLOW); International CALL Research Conference (CALL)

LANGUAGES & SKILLS

Languages: English (TEM-4, merit 93/100), Mandarin Chinese (native), French (basic), Irish (basic)

Data analysis: R, SQL, SPSS, Stata

Programming tools: Python, JavaScript/H, Java, GitHub

Linguistic tools: NVivo, Eyelink, Praat, PC Ibex Farm, CLAN

Other: Microsoft Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint), Latex (Overleaf), Graph Pad Prism, Origin